NONPROFIT LEARNING HUB

Grant Writing Fundamentals: A Guide for Northern Arizona Nonprofits

A practical guide from the Cinder Peaks Nonprofit Learning Hub

1. Start with fit

- Read the full guidelines or RFP before writing anything. Highlight the funder's priorities, geographic limits, and what it does not fund.
- Call the program officer. A ten-minute conversation can save you twenty hours of writing.
- Check the deadline time zone. Arizona does not observe daylight saving time, so Arizona deadlines are always Mountain Standard Time.

2. Describe the need clearly

- Use one or two local statistics, not ten. County-level data is usually more persuasive than national data.
- Include the voices of the people you serve, with their permission.
- Explain why your organization is well positioned to respond.

3. Describe your approach

- Say what you will do, who will do it, when, and for whom.
- Connect each activity to a result you expect to see.
- Name your partners and describe what each will contribute.

4. Build a realistic budget

- Every number in the narrative should match the budget.
- Include the full cost of the work, including staff time and a fair share of overhead.
- Show other sources of support, confirmed and pending.

5. Plan to measure results

- Choose two or three measures you can realistically track.
- Collect stories as well as numbers.
- Report honestly on what did not work. Funders value learning.

6. After you submit

- Send a short thank-you note whether or not the grant is awarded.
- If you are declined, ask for feedback.
- Put reporting due dates on your calendar as soon as you receive an award letter.

Common reasons applications are declined

Reason	How to avoid it
The request does not fit the program's priorities	Re-read the guidelines and call the program officer before applying.
The budget and narrative do not match	Have a colleague compare the two documents line by line.
The applicant is outside the eligible geography	Check the county list carefully, including where participants live.
The application is incomplete	Use the attachment checklist in the application worksheet.

Questions?

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